Voice of the Voiceless

Franchise Extension, the Press and Parliamentary Speech in the Netherlands, 1888–1925

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Abstract

Long before they could vote, industrial workers and, later, women had newspapers that spoke on their behalf. The political economy of democratisation explains who obtained the vote and what followed, but it rarely asks who had a voice before the vote, or what enfranchisement changed for groups whose claims were already being made in print. This paper studies that question in the Netherlands, where the electorate was enlarged in stages between 1888 and 1922 while the press had been free of taxation since 1869.

The constitutional revision of 1887 roughly doubled the number of registered voters, from about 135,000 to 292,000 at the election of March 1888, and redrew the country into 84 districts. The electoral law of 1896 nearly doubled the electorate again, to about 537,000 at the election of June 1897, by adding voters qualified through rent, wages, savings or examinations. Universal male suffrage and proportional representation followed with the revision of 1917, and women voted for the first time in 1922. None of these reforms changed the price of news, so they reverse the logic of the 1869 repeal of the newspaper stamp: the electorate changes while the press stays the same.

If legislators follow the press because its readers can vote, enlarging the reading electorate should raise responsiveness most where newspapers already reached the newly enfranchised. The paper tests two predictions. First, franchise extensions should raise district representatives' attention to the press and to the issues of the new voters (labour, housing, poor relief, public health and the franchise itself) in proportion to how much each reform enlarged the local electorate, and more so where newspapers were present before the reform. Second, enfranchisement may change the form of representation more than its volume: parliament may come to take up the specific claims the press had made on a group's behalf, rather than simply mention the group more often.

The empirical strategy exploits the fact that the reforms enlarged the electorate by very different amounts across districts, depending on the local distribution of taxes, rents and occupations. Districts that gained many voters are compared with districts that gained few, before and after each reform, in a difference-in-differences design with a continuous treatment. The preferred measure of the treatment is the increase in eligibility that the new rules imply for each district's pre-reform population, so that it does not reflect the party and newspaper mobilisation that drove registration; the registered electorate serves as a check. The reform of 1897, which left almost all district boundaries unchanged, provides the cleanest comparison; for 1888, outcomes are mapped onto common boundaries through the municipalities that made up each district. After 1918, when proportional representation abolished the districts, the paper traces descriptively how the gap between what the press demanded for each group and what parliament discussed moved around the enfranchisement of all men and of women.

The analysis rests on a speaker-linked corpus of the proceedings of both chambers from 1880 to 1926, built from the OCR of Staten-Generaal Digitaal, joined to district election returns

(Huygens ING, Kiesraad), municipal censuses and tax series, and the digitised Dutch press. Speeches and articles are classified into policy areas with a model adapted to historical Dutch, and the representation gap of each group is measured with lexicons that are re-estimated for each decade, so that changes in vocabulary are not mistaken for changes in representation.

Together with its companion paper on the 1869 repeal of the newspaper stamp, the paper tests the same mechanism from opposite directions: first the price of news changes with the electorate fixed, then the electorate changes with the price of news fixed.

Keywords: franchise extension; democratisation; representation; media and accountability; parliamentary speech; the Netherlands.
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